

The History of Roads in Michigan

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Indian Trails

The network of roadways that now serves Michigan began centuries ago as a network of Indian trails. These paths, worn deep by centuries of foot travel by the Indians, were located on high, dry ground along waterbeds and streams. They connected main Indian villages and let to the rich hunting and fishing grounds of the state. They linked the numerous rivers which covered the state, thus providing a continuous transportation system.

Some of the Indian trails which crisscrossed Michigan were segments of well-known trails connecting the Atlantic seaboard and the plains states. Michigan's earliest white men, explorers, missionaries and fur traders used these convenient paths as they traveled westward to penetrate the frontier. Later, they provided a way through the wild country for thousands of settlers who poured into Michigan to carve out homes in the wilderness.

These trails should not be confused, however, with modern highways or even the crude wagon roads built by the early settlers. An Indian trail was merely a narrow path, about 12 to 18 inches wide, permitting only single-file travel. It was not until the coming of the white settlers, laden with supplies, that the trails were improved. The use of the pack horse was the first step in the process of widening these pathways. Branches and bushes were broken off from each side of the trail and soon it was several feet wide. Later, when settlers flocked to Michigan Territory, bringing their possessions in oxen-drawn wagons, there was a need for even wider roads.

Nearly all of the principal highways radiating from Detroit, for example, once were narrow paths through forest and plain marked by blazed trees and campfire ashes. US-24 southward to Toledo originally was the westernmost segment of the Great Trail from Fort Pitt to Fort Detroit, linking up on the east with Braddock's Road from the Atlantic seaboard. On the Upper Peninsula, US-2 from Sault Ste. Marie to Escanaba and M-35 from Escanaba to Menominee follow the Sault and Green Bay Trail. From these and other main thoroughfares, lesser trails branched off. Many of them now are state or county roads.

Source: <http://www.michiganhighways.org/history.html>

